Establishing Perpetual Care at the Locust Grove Baptist Cemetery

By Linda Hasselstrom

INTRODUCTION

Linda Hasselstrom, who runs a cattle ranch in western South Dakota and has deep ties to the land, speaks eloquently on environmental subjects. In this collection of poems and essays she pays tribute to the people of the Great Plains and their way of life, taking issue with those who regard the area as an arid expanse fit only for waste dumps and exploitation. Writing movingly about the death of her husband and her efforts to cope with grief, she extols the virtues of hard physical work and the satisfactions of being close to the land. Using vivid images of wildlife and landscapes, the author challenges animal rights activists, praises the cow, makes a strong case for sustainability in agriculture. Establishing Perpetual Care at the Locust Grove Baptist Cemetery by Linda Hasselstrom.

A knock at the front door
echoes in the landlady's empty hall
tinkles past the crystal in the cabinet,

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drums across her kitchen floor to mine.
She's not home. Whoever it is will come
to my door next. I stretch,
drop the pen and fill the kettle.
Light the stove with a wooden match.

A stooped man in a black suit
rounds the corner, dust rising
behind his cane with every step.
Ancient sweat stains streak
the band of his straw hat
like layers in old sandstone.
He shuts the gate behind him.
Thumps the door four times
with a rugged fist.
Straightens his shoulders.

I snap the bolt open,
but stay behind the locked screen door.
"Good afternoon," I say.

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He pinches his hat with
two gnarled fingers, lifts, and says,
"Good day, Ma'am. I'm Walter Mathis
from up at Locust Grove."
He hangs the cane on one arm,
mops his forehead with a red kerchief,
tucks it in a shirt pocket. "Does Mrs.
Notye Murray still live here?"

He's afraid she's dead.
"Yes," I say. Adding the "Sir"
is automatic, involuntary, even.
"That's her door you knocked on."

"She's not home, then," he says,
nodding. Just what he thought.
He squints, leaning toward the screen.
"You her granddaughter?"

"No sir, just a tenant—I rent
this back apartment," I say.

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Because it's cheap, I think; because
I've left my husband
and have no money and no credit.
"When she goes out in the afternoon,
she's always back by dark," I say.
"Unless it's her whist night. But that's Thursday."

He leans back on his heels,
rapping the cane against the concrete step.
Eyes the packing plant fence
like he's tempted to get the hammer
and a fistful of nails out of the tool box
I know is behind the pickup seat,
fix the blasted thing so it'll stand up straight.
"Well," he mutters. "Let me think."
He yanks the hat brim down.

I unlock the screen door, step outside
to say, "She might be home earlier.
I'm not real sure where she was going
but if she went for poke salat

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and lambs quarters,
she might be home pretty soon."

"Cooks 'em up with bacon, I bet,"
he says, grinning. "Bet you never had
vittles like that, beings you are a northern lady."
He nods. Another thing he knew
without even thinking.
I nod right back at him. The cane
pounds once more on the step.
His mind's made up. "Well.
I gotta be gettin back to Locust Grove
so you tell Notye—you tell Miz Murray for me.
We gotta get goin on this perpetual care
for the cemetery up there. Us old-timers,
we figure maybe the next generation
won't be as interested in the folks there.
But her and me, we got close folks—
she's got her ma and pa and husband up there
and all my folks are together in that one spot."

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I nod again. Now I remember who I am,
even if I don't know where.
I can see the cemetery in my home town,
where once I could imagine
my husband's tombstone with mine beside it,
infinitely announcing our devotion.

He shoves the hat to wipe
his forehead on his sleeve,
yanks the brim back down. Nods again.
"Well, I live right by the cemetery, don't ya know.
Me an' Howard Breedlove and Walt Kinsolving—
that's my son-in-law—we all got together
cause folks been wanting to give me money
so there'd be some kind of continual care.
And I figgered if I just took money
even if I put it in a bank,
pretty soon some bank examiners'd
want to know what I'm doin,
and pretty soon after that
the income tax people

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would come a'sniffin around.

So we formed an association. I'm president.
Yep. Howard Breedlove's treasurer.
I come down here today to get papers
drawed up and signed. And I wanted to tell her
if she wants to send a check
to make it out right, to make it out to
The Locust Grove Baptist Cemetery Association.
I always mow the lawn, mowed it
seven times last year, charged forty dollars
an they paid me OK, but the year before
I mowed it ten times an there wasn't
enough money in the treasury to pay me
so I just give 'em the last one.
I lived there all my life and all my folks
are buried there. I usually got
some grandchildren to help me.
About your size."

Walter Mathis waves his cane,

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redeems me as his grandchild.
I'm ready to follow him home
to Locus Grove, learn to cook
poke salat just the way he likes it.

"Here now, you tell Miz. Murray
I come by and to make the check out
Locust Grove Baptist Cemetery Association."
He tips his hat again. "Good day to you, ma'am."

The kettle's boiling. While Walter's 1953 Ford pickup
lumbers down the street, I pour my tea,
take the cup upstairs and lean to look
out the bedroom window, to watch
until Walter Mathis turns left
on the gravel road out of town,
headed back to Locust Grove.
I sip my tea and know it's time
I headed home
where people recognize me,
where the cemetery dust

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is folks I knew.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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